So much did the Indian position harden vis-à-vis the United States that when the Truman administration suggested in August 1950 that Nationalist China (Formosa) be unseated from the Security Council and India put in its place rather than the People's Republic, Nehru rejected the suggestion with great vehemence and declared: '[W]e are not going in at the cost of China … we are not going to countenance it … We shall go on pressing for China's admission to the UN and the Security Council.'[46]

India's determination to prove its friendship to China and disprove Sino-Soviet charges of being the running dog of imperialism made it 'virtually impossible for Nehru to carry out his declared policy of non-alignment on merits'[47] – costing India the goodwill of the United States without any corresponding benefit from the Communist Bloc.

THE ESTABLISHMENT OF the People's Republic, with its irredentist claims on Tibet – till then acknowledged as an autonomous country subject to Chinese suzerainty – profoundly changed the security situation on India's northern frontier. This was a fact that Nehru, despite his Sinophilia and his desire for friendship with China, was acutely aware of, having been warned by Ambassador Panikkar as early as in November 1949 about the prospect of a Chinese invasion of Tibet by June 1950.[48] As the legal successor to British India, India had (in theory at least) inherited all the rights and obligations from treaties between British India and Tibet. These included, among others, the delineation of the McMahon line in the Simla Convention of 1914.[49] This was a position that Nehru himself reiterated when he rejected a Chinese request to renegotiate and revise the Tibet Trade Regulations in 1948.[50] Chinese occupation of Tibet threatened to place all of these inherited rights, including the recognition of the McMahon Line, in jeopardy – a fact that Nehru himself appreciated.

In fact, as early as 1948 itself, the assumption that a strong Chinese government would attempt to seize Tibet, repudiate the McMahon Line and advance claims on Indian territories was already widely shared in the halls